

need. Leave about 24 in (60 cm) between summer and fall cauliflowers, and 28 in (70 cm) between winter and spring varieties. If you wish to grow miniature cauliflowers, choose fast-growing early summer varieties and plant seedlings about 6 in (15 cm) apart. The crowded environment will cause growth to be stunted, producing heads that are approximately 1.5–3 in (4–8 cm) in width.

CROP CARE

Young seedlings are a tempting delicacy for pests, so fit brassica collars (see pests and diseases box, below) to deter cabbage root fly, and use netting to prevent birds and butterflies from getting at crops. Keep cauliflowers free from



At this height, seedlings are ready to plant.

weeds, but most importantly, keep them well-watered; they are thirsty crops that require a lot of water during growth. Without sufficient water, they may bolt or produce small, premature heads. Give winter and spring cauliflowers an organic liquid feed or nitrogenous fertilizer in late winter or early

PESTS AND DISEASES

Cauliflowers are prone to the pests and diseases that trouble all brassicas, so take the same precautions as for cabbages (see pp.246–7): place brassica collars around the stems of vulnerable seedlings, net plants against attack from birds, and as best you can, guard against clubroot as this disease is incurable and can persist in the soil for decades. Cauliflowers are also prone to boron and magnesium deficiencies.



Construct a frame out of bamboo canes and fasten your netting to it.